



own goals — came from Lynda and Jennifer, with Lynda netting a brace against Lion City Sailors and Jennifer securing qualification with a double against Etihad FC.

"I have earned a lot of experience playing here, especially with the seniors. When I came to the club, I was very young, but I've learned how to train and maintain my body. It has also helped me grow in football," Lynda told *Sportstar*.

Uphill battle in Champions League

OFCW's dream run to the AWCL is nothing short of inspiring. However, in its first match in the Champions League, it was left to pick up the pieces after a 0-17 thrashing by the defending Asian champion from Japan, Urawa Red Diamonds, on October 6.

The Red Diamonds had steamrolled Gokulam Kerala 8-0 in the AFC Women's Club Championship last year, scoring four goals in each half. Against OFCW, it handed Indian football another reality check, highlighting the gulf in quality between the two sides at the Thong Nhat Stadium in Vietnam. The Japanese side had a staggering 55 shots compared to Odisha's solitary

effort throughout the game.

The Juggernauts are travelling with a depleted squad, with five players missing out due to injury and transfer restrictions.

Pyari and goalkeeper Anshika are injured, midfielder Grace Haunhar is suspended for five matches, and new signing, Cameroonian defender Elaine Boddolo wasn't granted the International Transfer Certificate (ITC) by FIFA.

Additionally, Indian forward Munica Minz and defender Kretina Sangma missed the group-stage squad due to visa issues.

The team will next play Ho Chi Minh City from Vietnam on October 9 and Taichung Blue Whale from Chinese Taipei three days later in its remaining group-stage matches.

Despite the odds stacked against them, Chhetri believes his team will not throw in the towel.

"I think it's the greatest platform to learn from. But are we going there just to learn? No. I'm training every day, and I want my players to go there to win matches. At the same time, there is no pressure on them. We go there, give our 100 per cent, enjoy the game, and come back learning," Chhetri said.

Triumphant trio: Jennifer Kankam Yeboah, Pyari Xaxa and Lynda Kom Serto are vital to OFCW's success.

Regardless of the team's performance, it is assured a sum of \$100,000 (approx. ₹88.3 lakh), which is over eight times the prize money of the IWL (₹10 lakh). Chhetri believes this will help nurture women's football, not only at the club but also in India. "Everything is about money. It's not just about paying players because everybody needs security, especially women players, who are constantly asked why they aren't getting married," Chhetri explained. "Moreover, with the money, we can invest in their basic facilities – the training pitch, accommodation, food, and travel, because we want to create professional players."

With two trophies in as many years and a spot in Asia, OFCW has become a leading example of Indian women's football making significant progress in a short period of time.

While the results may not be favourable for the Juggernauts in their maiden AWCL campaign, they can take plenty of learnings back home and aim to return stronger next time.